

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ J 6 5 2

♥ 10 8 4

♦ A 3

♣ 10 9 8 3

♠ K Q 7

♥ A 6 3

♦ Q 10 6 4

♣ Q J 5



♠ A 10 9 4 3

♥ J 9 7 2

♦ 7

♣ K 7 4

♠ 8

♥ K Q 5

♦ K J 9 8 5 2

♣ A 6 2

West	North	East	South
			1 ♦
Pass	2NT	Pass	3 ♦
Pass	5 ♦		
All Pass			

5 ♦ by South

Instead, win the first trick and immediately play your ♠ toward dummy's ♠ K Q. A defender will probably take this trick but you don't care. They will play another ♣ to try to set up a trick in the suit but you can win the ♣, enter dummy with the ♥ A, and discard your "slow" ♣ loser on dummy's good ♠ honor.

And then, with that important job done, you can lead trumps.

Bridge is a game of timing, and sometimes the tempo of the game is set by the opening lead.

Suppose West's opening lead was a ♠, a ♥ or a ♦. You would have still had the same 3 losers, but now the ♣ loser would have been "very slow". So slow that you could start on trumps before working on the ♠s.

In other words, with one of these opening leads a mediocre player, one who had never read this lesson, would probably make the contract without any trouble. But with the ♣ lead only a skilled declarer would make it!

South is to play 5 ♦. West leads the ♣ 10. You play dummy's ♣ J and East puts on the ♣ K.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 3

The ♠ loser and ♦ loser are "fast" losers, meaning your opponents can take them whenever they are in the lead. The ♣ loser is a "slow" loser, meaning you might have some time to dispose of it.

But here is the problem. If you start to draw trumps, a defender will take the ♦ A and play another ♣, forcing out your ♣ Q. Then, when you play a ♠ they will jump in with the ♠ A and take their ♣ trick. Anything you can think of to do about that?

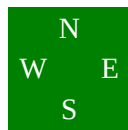
Once you recognize the problem, the solution is easier to see. Don't play trumps next!

Board 3

South Deals
None Vul

♠ J 9
♥ Q 10 6 5
♦ Q 9 2
♣ J 10 9 4

♠ 7 4
♥ A K 4 2
♦ A 8 5 4
♣ Q 6 2



♠ Q 10 8 3 2
♥ J 9 7
♦ 10 6
♣ 8 7 3

♠ A K 6 5
♥ 8 3
♦ K J 7 3
♣ A K 5

West	North	East	South
			1♦
Pass	1♥	Pass	1♠
Pass	3♦	Pass	4♣
Pass	4♥	Pass	6♦
All Pass			
6♦ by South else.			

The 4♣ and 4♥ bids were control-showing. South is to play 6♦. West leads the ♣J.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=0 Total = 4

That loser count may be technically correct but actually it's wonky. As long as ♦s split 3-2 like they should you only have 1 loser in the suit. And if East has the ♦Q you can finesse and have no losers. Also, those 2 ♠ losers could be ruffed in dummy.

Suppose you tried it like this: Win the ♣, play ♦A, then a ♦ to the ♦J, then pull the last trump with your ♦K. That would only leave one trump in dummy for ruffing ♠ losers, but you could make the slam.

But suppose the ♦ finesse lost to West. And further suppose that West then played another ♦. Since only 1 ♠ could be ruffed you'd be down 1. Try something

Win the ♣. Play the ♦A and ♦K, forgetting about even trying the finesse. If the ♦Q falls that's good, but if it doesn't, no problem, just leave it out there. Then start on your other high cards. Take 2 more ♣s, 2 ♠s, and 2 ♥s. Then start cross-ruffing the last 4 ♠s and ♥s. The ♦Q guy can trump in whenever he likes but you will make 12 tricks.

This is the complete deal.

again to see what would have happened if you had finessed in trumps.

Suppose you had won the first ♣, then played ♦A and lost the ♦ finesse to West's ♦Q. West might have then played his last trump back to your ♦J and the hands would look like this.

You need the rest of the tricks but the best you can do now is to take the two high ♣s, the two high ♥s, the two high ♠s, one ♥ ruff in your hand and one ♠ ruff in dummy. Letting West pull that third round of trumps did you in.

This is how it would have looked if you had won the first ♣ trick, then just played the ♦A and ♦K, not trying the trump finesse.

Leaving the master trump out, you would now proceed to take your two high ♣s, two high ♥s and two high ♠s.

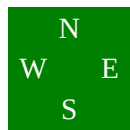
Needing just three more tricks, and with two trumps in each hand you just cross-ruff ♥s and ♠. West can ruff in with the ♦Q at some point but he cannot prevent you from winning at least three of your trumps separately.

Board 5

North Deals
None Vul

♠ J 10 5 3
♥ Q J 10 3
♦ 10 8 3
♣ 9 3

♠ A 8 2
♥ K 6 5
♦ K 4 2
♣ Q J 7 4



♠ 6
♥ A 8 7 2
♦ Q J 9 7
♣ 10 8 5 2

♠ K Q 9 7 4
♥ 9 4
♦ A 6 5
♣ A K 6

West	North	East	South
	1♣	Pass	1♠
Pass	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by South
on the third ♥ which you ruff.

South's 2♦ bid was New Minor Forcing, asking if North has 3 ♠s. North's 2♠ response said "Yes, I have." South is to play 4♠. West leads the ♥Q.

Losers: ♠ = ? ♥ = 2 ♦ = 1 ♣ = 0 Total = 3?

If the ♠s split 3-2 as they should, you have no ♠ loser and your plan will merely be to pull trumps and play winners. So what you do in that case is start figuring how to deal with a 4-1 split.

But first you should deal with the ♥K situation. Do you cover the ♥Q or not?

Competent defenders do not underlead Aces at suit contracts. So if you are playing against a competent West you certainly don't cover. You play low on this trick and on the ♥J continuation, hoping East started with a doubleton ♥A. But he didn't, and he plays it

Back to the Plan. Having ruffed the ♥ you are down to just 4 trumps in your hand. You play ♠A, ♠K, ♠Q, noting that East discards on the second round. Therefore West will get a trump trick.

But don't give it to him now! Leave West with his master trump and switch to ♣s. If West doesn't ruff at all you will run 4 ♣ tricks and discard your ♦ loser. If he does decide to ruff it will be with a trick you were going to lose anyway. You win his return, ruffing a ♥ with the last trump, and continue playing ♣ and ♦ winners.

You can't help losing two ♥s and one ♠.

But you don't have to lose anything else as long as you don't lose trump control. So leave the master trump with West and just cash your minor suit winners. Let West ruff whenever he wants to because that will establish your ♠9 to control any more ♥ leads. If he decides not to ruff at all then he can have the final trick with his high trump.